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PART THREE

Critical Perspectives: Christian Pacifism and Feminism

Christian Nonviolence: An Interpretation

Theodore J. Koontz

I HAVE FOUR AIMS in this chapter. The first is to describe briefly something of the range of views that may fit under the heading “Christian nonviolence.” The second is to give an account of the context out of which it makes sense to be committed to a certain kind of Christian nonviolence (“pacifism”). The third is to note how, from this pacifist perspective, the questions posed to the contributors to this volume are not the central questions about peace and war, and how focusing on them in fact distorts our thinking. The fourth is to attempt, nevertheless, to deal with these questions from this pacifist perspective. Needless to say, a discussion that includes all of these issues will be rather sketchy.

VARIETIES OF CHRISTIAN NONVIOLENCE

There are a number of ways to classify views that might be seen as belonging to the “family” of Christian nonviolence. John H. Yoder presents over twenty different “pacifist” views, and Peter Brock, the dean of historians of Christian pacifism, identifies six pacifist views, all of which are essentially subsets of the first tradition I outline below.¹ Each of these views has a somewhat different basis, rationale, and perspective, and each might approach the questions addressed in this book in a somewhat different way.

For our purposes, I note three versions of Christian nonviolence—pacifism, abolitionism, and nonviolent resistance. None of these is exclusively “Christian.” Historically, however, the first view is more closely tied to Christian thought in the West than the other two views, whose advocates have been more diverse.²

A comment on terminology is in order. Language here is confusing. “Pacifism” originally meant something closer to what I am calling “abolitionism,” and people who are what I am calling “pacifists” previously often called themselves “nonresistants” and sharply differentiated themselves from “pacifists,” that is, abolitionists.³ The term “pacifism” has evolved in ways parallel, perhaps, to the term “liberalism” in politics, with parallel confusions. I use the term the way I do because I think this is closer to common usage today. There is also no agreement on what to call what was formerly called “pacifism.” Essentially, what was called “pacifism” is what

I am calling “abolitionism.” The same basic perspective has been described by other authors and given different labels: “pacific-ism” by Martin Ceadel and “utopian pacifism” by James Turner Johnson, for example.⁴ The first form of nonviolence, pacifism, is also the oldest. It is—minimally—the view that it is *morally* wrong for *me* to participate *directly* in *killing* in *all war*. Each of the italicized terms is important in carving out a minimal definition of pacifism. Pacifists often make larger claims (it is morally wrong for *everyone*, *all* killing is wrong, etc.), and the definition includes persons making such larger claims also. The term “pacifism” is, however, sometimes used to refer to those who have a strong desire for peace or aversion to war, but who are not necessarily committed to personal nonparticipation in all wars. This view is not included in my usage.

Pacifism, as understood here, was the dominant (though by no means only) position of Christians for the first three centuries of the Christian movement, the position of the early Waldensians, the early Unity of the Czech Brethren, and the Anabaptists. It has been and is the predominant (and official) position of Mennonites (and the related Amish), Quakers (Friends), and the Church of the Brethren.⁵ In recent centuries, especially, one also finds an increasing number of individuals and subgroups within nonpacifist denominations who are pacifists. I will focus here primarily on the historical pacifist groups.

In the West, pacifism typically has been rooted in specifically Christian theological claims. It focuses on the need for *Christians* to live and act on Christian standards, rather than on what often seem to representatives of this tradition like less-than-Christian standards. It focuses on creating a new society, made up of believers who are committed to governing their lives together by those standards. It does not necessarily claim to offer readily applicable policy advice to public officials on matters of war and peace. It typically stresses the need for conversion in order to enable persons and communities to live nonviolently, defenselessly, and is most often pessimistic about the prospects of peace in a world that does not know Christ. Although pacifists know that sometimes turning the other cheek is effective in transforming the enemy, they tend to stress readiness to accept suffering as an essential part of the disarmed life.

The second tradition I call “abolitionism.” Within this tradition, there is a commitment to abolish the evil of war, in a way somewhat parallel to the way in which there developed a commitment to abolish the evil of slavery. War in this view is no more an inherent part of life or a necessary evil than slavery was. There is a moral mandate to set up a world system that will make war obsolete. There is a great moral revulsion against war, and a skepticism about its utility that is typically absent from “realist” and just war writings. At the same time, there is an optimism about getting rid of war that is typically absent from just war and realist thought, and from

much pacifist thought. And, in contrast to pacifists, abolitionists do not *necessarily* (though some do) firmly refuse to participate in all wars. There is a focus on transforming the whole world (not on living a new life in an alternative society made up of those who have voluntarily chosen to follow Christ's way), and there is a confidence in human nature (apart from conversion) and in education—helping people see the evident follies and costs of war as a means of settling conflicts—that is quite different from the most typical expressions of Christian pacifism.

The abolitionist tradition goes back at least to Erasmus and is not as exclusively Christian in its membership as the pacifist tradition. Nor is it as necessarily Christian, meaning it depends less upon uniquely Christian theological claims. Immanuel Kant's scheme for perpetual peace, along with other world-peace plans propounded by figures such as William Penn (among others), reflect this perspective.⁶ Various peace societies that emerged in the nineteenth century in England and the United States came to have predominantly this coloring.⁷ This was the dominant mode of American and British "liberal pacifists" in the early part of this century.⁸ In a less nearly pacifist form, it also was behind the internationalism and idealism that led to the formation of the League of Nations and the United Nations. Throughout the last two decades or so, this viewpoint finds embodiment in its more radical form in much of the "peace movement," and in a less radical form in groups like the World Policy Institute that press for a more effective international community, often including removal of military force from the hands of independent states.

It is worth noting that although the tone and ethos of these first two "types" of Christian nonviolence are quite different, they are not incompatible in a fundamental sense: one could be (many have been) a pacifist—one personally refusing service in all wars—and an abolitionist. Thus, though it is helpful to differentiate them, they should not be separated too sharply.

The third member of this "family" we might best call "nonviolent resistance." Though the name stresses *resistance*, and though this perspective has been developed most fully in settings where the need for resistance to unjust political power is a primary motivating factor, the perspective also includes efforts to find ways of *defending* relatively just political systems from aggression (or, to make this compatible with our terminology, ways of *resisting* aggression).

This perspective is characterized, especially in relation to "pacifism" as portrayed here, by its insistence that there are normally (if not always) pragmatically effective nonviolent means of "fighting" that are viable alternatives to war and military conflict and that can achieve or protect crucial values. Although its chief practitioners can be, and often have been, pacifists in the sense of renouncing all use of arms on ethical grounds, this

position does not necessarily rely on a theological/ethical argument, though such an argument is often part of the case made for this view. What distinguishes it from “pacifism” is its stress both on the effectiveness of nonviolent action and on the need for active involvement in the pursuit of justice. The Gandhian movement in India and the civil rights movement in the United States led by Martin Luther King, Jr. have been the chief inspirations for this viewpoint. The chief intellectual architect of this position in the contemporary secular Western world is Gene Sharp of the Albert Einstein Institution in Cambridge, Massachusetts, which is probably the major research center devoted specifically to “advancing the study and use of strategic nonviolent action in conflicts throughout the world.” Central to this view is the claim that power depends upon the consent—or acquiescence—of the governed. This means that the tyranny of governments can be overcome through nonviolent resistance and that countries can be defended against aggression nonviolently. Adherents to this view do not necessarily hope that threats, including military threats, will disappear as better conflict-resolution mechanisms evolve and as people and groups become more internationalist in outlook (as abolitionists seem to hope). Instead they argue that there are effective nonviolent means for dealing with such threats—as the first view often does not assume.

As the mention of Martin Luther King, Jr. suggests, there are important bridges between “pacifist” commitment (as defined above), Christian theological understanding and commitment, and certain strands of nonviolent resistance to evil. King’s own writings reflect these bridges, combining a theologically based commitment to nonviolence and an activist commitment to the pursuit of justice. Thus, as he shows, Christian “pacifism” and Christian “nonviolent resistance” belong together, even though intentionally moving to confront evil, as King did, often has not characterized pacifist groups. In its Christian versions, “nonviolent resistance” relies less on pragmatic claims about effectiveness, stressing especially both the need to identify with the poor and marginalized and the cost of doing so.⁹ Nevertheless, those holding such views do generally seem to have a greater hope for the transformation of entire societies through effective nonviolent struggle than is typical of most pacifist groups historically.

The overthrow of communist regimes in Eastern Europe and the former Soviet Union is seen by advocates of nonviolent resistance as providing recent and dramatic evidence in favor of this perspective. From this vantage point, it is striking in light of recent events in Eastern Europe, the Philippines, and Iran (to mention only the places where “revolutions” have taken place essentially along lines advocated by persons like Sharp) that the power of nonviolence is not reflected more in the essays here. Surely it is the case that such power does not always “win,” as Tiananmen Square shows. But the same is true of violence. Don’t these events challenge some

of the basic assumptions of realism and just war theory, or at least raise questions about when we have reached last resort? What would it mean to take these experiences seriously as we seek to rethink our views about ethics and war?

I hope this brief description is useful in showing that these pacifist views are different in significant ways. At the same time, it is important to note that they are not necessarily opposed to one another in important respects. In fact, they often overlap and intermingle. One could, for example, be a pacifist who promoted strengthening international institutions and who advocated nonviolent defense. These three members of the Christian nonviolence “family” share, in contrast to most realist or just war views, an understanding of power that is not easily correlated with the ability to coerce or force others to do one’s bidding through military means. Even though pacifists stress the power of persuasion and example (rooted for Christian pacifists in the power of suffering love and God’s overarching power or control), abolitionists emphasize the power of reason and common interests, and advocates of nonviolent resistance underscore the power of withdrawing consent through nonviolent actions, each group in its own way disputes the claim that power grows out of the barrel of the gun. Thus these viewpoints are less inclined to see the “necessity” of war than are most other views “outside the family.”

UNDERSTANDING CHRISTIAN PACIFISM

In this section, I am intentionally narrowing the focus to the first of the three views outlined in the previous section, and to one version of that view. Even so, the task is not an easy one. How does one make Christian pacifist commitment intelligible to the wise of the world? I frankly doubt that it can be done. But if it can, I believe the only possible way to proceed is by seeking to show how reality looks from within the world of those (or some of those—there is diversity) who hold this view, not by arguing for it.¹⁰

“Showing how reality looks” from this Christian pacifist perspective requires challenging some assumptions that we commonly make, and that are made in this book. One such assumption is that we come to know the truth primarily through intellectual argument and exchange, and, perhaps, that there is something like “neutral” ground on the basis of which to judge alternatives. A closely related assumption is that a conference or a classroom is the primary venue through which we come to know the truth. I do not intend to argue here that these assumptions are wrong. I do not know how to make such an argument. But I do want to claim that these are not the assumptions that Christian pacifists make, and that if one wants to understand why some people are Christian pacifists, one must suspend

these assumptions and enter their (our) world on their (our) terms. In making this claim, I do not mean to say that such activities are illegitimate, or to claim that we Christian pacifists do not engage in them (I make my living, after all, standing in front of a class and attending conferences), or to put what I say beyond the reach of criticism. But I do mean to say that when we engage in intellectual arguments with those outside the Christian pacifist tradition, we are speaking, as it were, a “second language,” and we are doing so in a context that is not our “home.”

Worship, it seems to me, is where Christian pacifists are most deeply at home, where they (we) come to know the truth, where we speak our first, our deepest, language. It is in this context of worship, with its “language” of hymns, prayers, sermons, stories, testimonies, confession, praise, celebration, and communion, that Christians come to know God’s will. One might well state it even more forcefully. It is worship that in fact constitutes and defines the community. It is worship that creates and sustains it. Worship is not mainly an activity the community undertakes, but its reason for being, that which makes it a community.¹¹

Thus much of what gives power and vitality to the tradition of Christian pacifism cannot be perceived in a book like the one you are reading. Our “truth” is apt to be invisible here, or in an academic conference. Nevertheless, I can seek to open a small window onto the world of Christian pacifism by bringing a part of our “worship” before you. I have chosen to do so through an excerpt from a sermon I preached one Palm Sunday. There is nothing exceptional about the sermon. Indeed, that is the point. In important respects it is typical of the viewpoint that Christian pacifists hold and that shapes their (our) understandings of ethics, war, and peace. It was titled, “Blessed Is the King!”

I began the sermon by noting that in two important respects Palm Sunday is a Sunday of false hope: first, because it proclaimed a victory before it was won—Jesus, the one who was proclaimed messiah on Palm Sunday, was arrested and crucified within the week; and second, because Jesus was not the kind of messiah the people wanted. He did not break the power of Rome and restore the glory of the Davidic kingdom. Yet the Christian Gospel claims that he is king, messiah, that he is victorious, powerful. How can this be?

His is a strange victory, a strange power. Victory came, and can come, but in a radically different way than the Palm Sunday crowds expected. The victory of Jesus is not a popular, political, national liberation victory. It is a victory that is realized when it takes root in the hearts and minds of people who have eyes to see and ears to hear and who form communities to celebrate the victory they see and hear. It is a victory that the powers that rule in the capitals of the world can, if they choose, simply pretend is not real, at least for a very long time. It is

a victory that conquers no one except as they open themselves to it. Yet it is a victory that is extremely hard to resist if one does open one's eyes to see, and does unstop one's ears to hear. And it is a victory that freed and empowered those frightened first disciples when they finally saw it, heard it, even while the structures of Roman power remained unshaken. While it is a victory that threatens, and ultimately overcomes, the resistance of the enemy, it is a victory that can be experienced, celebrated, lived, even while the enemy still sits smugly on his throne.

The victory of Jesus is also strange because it is not the work of a dedicated band of revolutionaries who seized the reins of power in order to remake human history. Rather, the victory of Jesus, confirmed in his resurrection, is one that comes by Another's hand. Whatever else Christian faith may mean, it surely has something to do with affirming this kind of surprising, powerful, renewing action by God. It means not finally resting our hopes on ourselves or on other humans, although we surely have our part.

If the shape of the victory of Jesus is strange, so too is the power that wins the victory. I think it is their failure to recognize this strange power as *true* power that causes Jesus to say of the people of Jerusalem as he overlooks the city, "If only you had recognized the things that make for peace" (Luke 19:42). One way to describe this power that makes for peace is to call it the power of vulnerability. It is the power that comes when defenses fall, when fear of being hurt or killed disappears, when one is no longer interested in defending oneself, but in doing God's will. When we no longer seek to protect or defend ourselves, when we make ourselves fully vulnerable, we are free. Of course we can be killed. But nothing can deter us from doing or saying what we believe is true. When we accept vulnerability, literally nothing has power over us.

For many years I had puzzled over what it might mean to say, as Paul does in Colossians 2:15, Jesus "disarmed the principalities and powers and made a public example of them, triumphing over them in it (the cross)."

How did Jesus disarm the powers, or make a public example of them through the cross? What is the nature of the power that this King Jesus exercises, the nature of the power that he offers to us?

I was helped to understand this by remembering the story of "The Emperor's New Clothes" by Hans Christian Andersen. . . . The emperor in the story is not that different from many modern "emperors," who won't admit to mistakes or sins for fear that doing so will undermine their authority. They would rather pretend they are not naked—stripped of the moral right to rule—and punish those who point out that they are, than to change their ways.

More important, the people around Andersen's emperor are not that different from many modern people, who, fearing punishment or loss of position, go along with their emperor's pretensions. There is a powerful incentive for officials, and for ordinary citizens, to pretend they don't see the emperor's nakedness because emperors often torture and kill those who expose them.

But despite this, the power or authority of emperors is still dependent on the people being willing to go along with emperors' claims to "legitimacy" (the emperor's moral *right* to rule). If ever there has been a historical moment when the truth of this claim ought to be evident, it is now. Within the last fifteen years we have witnessed the fall of incredibly powerful regimes that could not withstand the power of people who were willing to say, "The emperor is naked!" From Iran, to the Philippines, to Eastern Europe, to the Soviet Union, change that was unimaginable, and that could not be brought about by force of arms, has taken place. As my colleague Walter Sawatsky and others have shown, central to the changes in the East was a commitment of a few to begin speaking and living the truth, a commitment to refuse participation in the lie, a commitment to begin living now "as if" honesty, freedom, and human decency were already the norms by which society ran.¹² It is simply true, to turn to another source of authority for Americans, the US Declaration of Independence, that governments derive their "powers from the consent of the governed." When enough people, despite fear of repression, see and *say* of illegitimate regimes, with the child in Andersen's story, that the emperor is naked, then his power is gone, because his power is based on fear. What is most remarkable about governments is not their incredible capability to repress dissent but their fragility when their moral nakedness is exposed.

This, I think, is what Jesus showed us. Jesus had power over the powers that be because their power *is*, finally, dependent on the acquiescence of the people—and Jesus refused to acquiesce. Jesus stripped the emperor's power over him because he did not let fear of what the authorities could do to him force him to pretend the emperor was clothed. Since, when consent is absent, terror is the only kind of power left to emperors, Jesus did, in fact, "disarm" the powers that be, he "made a public example of them" showing not only their illegitimacy but also their literal "powerlessness" in the face of those who refuse to be terrorized. Thus he "triumphed over them," precisely "in the cross."

The key to this triumph, though, is overcoming fear, accepting vulnerability. So long as we are ruled by fear, we can be neither free nor powerful. How can we overcome fear, accept the possibility of the cross, live lives that are, paradoxically, both fully vulnerable, and wonderfully powerful? I believe that the key lies in really seeing, in really *believing*, that Jesus is King. Though we take for granted the Kingship of Jesus and, unlike the people of his time, understand that his Kingship is radically different from that of worldly kings, I wonder if we *really* understand, I wonder if we *really* believe.

I remember the power of Martin Luther King, Jr., and how that power required overcoming fear. He lived with constant threats, and survived a number of attacks aimed at him. Perhaps a small sense of the pressure under which he lived can be gained by recalling the story told by Joan Baez of a meeting with King in 1964, four years before he was killed. King, Baez, and another friend went to a restaurant at an odd hour for a quiet conversation. At a table nearby in

the nearly empty restaurant there was a group of men sitting, watching them. Curious about what they were doing, she went over and asked them. Sheepishly, they answered that they were reporters who had been assigned to follow King wherever he went. Their purpose was to be there so that they would have the scoop when the inevitable happened and King was assassinated. Shaken, but seeking to act normal, Baez returned to King's table and sat down. Before she could say anything, King said quietly and matter-of-factly, "They are waiting for me to be killed, aren't they?"

Now King, like Jesus, is a heroic, larger-than-life figure. We may not be called to live with such radical vulnerability. Their examples may seem irrelevant to us. Yet I think we often fail to choose the power of vulnerability, even though we have a very small amount to lose by choosing *that* power instead of the power of self-protection, the power of hiding behind the emperor's clothes. If you are like me, you often have refused to speak to someone with whom you disagree and have allowed a barrier to grow between you, because of fear of confrontation. If you are like me, you have sometimes failed to speak to friends about things that trouble you concerning their behavior. If you are like me, you have sought to block potential criticism by issuing a quick and superficial "I'm sorry," or simply by avoiding one who may have reason to admonish you. If you are like me, you often do not speak of that which matters most to you, about your faith, about your fears, about your dreams, about your failures, yes, even about your sins. If you are like me, you often do not reach out deeply to those near you who face struggles, because entering deeply into their struggles may mean exposing and facing your own struggles. Behind all these failures to live freely, powerfully, vulnerably, lies fear, fear growing out of our desire to protect ourselves. And to the extent that our lives are shaped by fear, to that extent we testify that we, like the people of Jesus' time, do not understand, do not believe, that Jesus is really King. Have we, any more than the disciples, really seen the new thing that Jesus did?

In this regard, I was struck by the text, "Do not remember the former things, or consider the things of old. I am about to do a new thing; now it springs forth, do you not perceive it?" (Isa. 43:18–19). We all have been well trained to see the "old things," to understand, and use, the kind of power that the Kings of this world use, though, of course, on our own modest scale. It is a power that seeks to perpetuate and solidify our ability to make ourselves *invulnerable*. It is the kind of power that has dominated the writing of history. A challenge to this view of power, this view of how history moves, is at the center of Christian faith. It is an illusory power, as Jesus' defeat of the powers shows, yet it is an illusory power that has a tenacious grip on us. When we can open ourselves to the Kingly, yes, even the Godly power of Jesus, when we can say "Blessed is *this* King," when we can overcome fear with love because we know that God is love and that God is all-powerful, when we can see the new thing that the Kingship of Jesus teaches us—when we can do these things we will become strangely powerful, we will be

blessed with the power of God. Of course, exercising this kind of power sometimes will be costly. But when we truly see the power of Jesus, we also will see that the risk is worth it, for it is through accepting the power of vulnerability that we find abundant life. It is, after all, our servant-King, Jesus, the one who reveals to us God's nature, who promised, "Those who find their life will lose it, and those who lose their life for my sake will find it" (Matt. 10:39). We have nothing essential to lose in choosing to live by relying on Jesus's sort of power. And we have authentic life itself to find.

If one enters into the world of a people shaped by this kind of sermon, one will note that some additional widely held assumptions come into question. These include the assumption that we have a "right" to violently defend ourselves from harm, the assumption that we have a responsibility to ensure that we and our neighbors are not harmed by enemies if it is within our physical ability to do so, the assumption that we have the responsibility to provide an ethic for rulers that they can use and still maintain their domineering power, and the assumption, which seems to lie behind the idea that war is sometimes "necessary," that the most powerful power is the ability to force others, by physical threat or force, to do what we want them to do. Of course, the cross symbolizes the fact that Jesus's sort of power is not without cost. But then, neither is the power of war.

TOPICS

The nature of the questions we raise is as important as the answers to our questions. Which questions guide our lives? Which questions do we make our own? . . . Finding the right questions is as crucial as finding the right answers.¹³

Before addressing directly the questions assigned that provide the point of departure for the essays in this volume, I want to reflect on them a bit more. A helpful place to begin is with Henri Nouwen's devotional book, *Lifesigns*. He observes the extraordinary degree to which fear drives us, controls us, and how this fear is rooted in accepting fear-full questions as our own.

We are often seduced by the fearful questions the world presents to us. Without fully realizing it, we become anxious, nervous, worrying people caught in the questions of survival. . . . Once these fearful survival questions become the guiding questions of our lives, we tend to dismiss words spoken from the house of love as unrealistic, romantic, sentimental, pious, or just useless. When love is offered as an alternative to fear we say: "Yes, yes, that sounds beautiful, but. . . ." The "but" reveals how much we live in the grip of the world, a world which calls Christians naive and raises "realistic" questions. . . .

When we raise these “realistic” questions we echo a cynical spirit which says: “Words about peace, forgiveness, reconciliation, and new life are wonderful but the real issues cannot be ignored. They require that we do not allow others to play games with us, that we retaliate when we are offended, that we are always ready for war. . . .

Once we accept these questions as our own, and are convinced that we must find answers to them, we become more and more settled in the house of fear. When we consider how much of our . . . lives are geared to finding answers to questions born of fear, it is not hard to understand why a message of love has little chance of being heard.

Fearful questions never lead to love-filled answers. . . . Fear engenders fear. Fear never gives birth to love.¹⁴

I sense that the questions we are to address are questions coming from “the house of fear.” I am convinced that “defensive” or “justifiable” war is one of the deepest expressions of fear in human life, despite the undoubted courage of many who fight such wars. The questions, and “good” wars, are expressions of fear because they suggest that, unless we at least hold open the option of engaging in the carnage that war brings, what we care about will be destroyed.

This is, of course, a “realistic” fear. Yet Nouwen suggests that when we allow such a fear to dominate us, “we are back again in the house of fear.” And he holds the conviction that “love is stronger than fear, though it may often seem that the opposite is true. ‘Perfect love casts out all fear,’ says St. John in his first letter.” The question, he suggests, is this: “Is it possible in the midst of this fear-provoking world to live in the house of love and listen there to the questions raised by the Lord of love? Or are we so accustomed to living in fear that we have become deaf to the voice that says: ‘Do not be afraid.’”¹⁵

What questions pertinent to our topic would we claim as our own if we lived in “the house of love,” if we listened to the questions raised by the Lord of love? I do not have the answer to that. Some of my thinking on it, however, is reflected in the section below, “Morality in Extremity.” Surely our questions would focus our attention much more on building peace than on asking when we may go to war. Generally, the key questions for Christian pacifists would be like these, I think: “How can we be conformed to the mind of Christ, enflesh his power? How can we incarnate God’s radical, enemy-loving compassion, revealed in Jesus, in this case, in that situation? How can we break down the dividing walls of hostility?” More specifically, the questions may take these forms, as they have for particular friends and colleagues of mine in the last several months: “Should I leave my wife and two small children to return to Somalia for more peace-building talks, even though the last time I was there for that purpose I lost my

leg and almost my life?” “Should I uproot my family with school-aged children so that I can work with other Christians to strengthen commitment to reconciliation in Serbia, Croatia, and Bosnia?” “Should we postpone or forego our plans for graduate school in order to volunteer for three years as teachers in an isolated West Bank village?” “Should we move our family to Mozambique so we can work with churches there in rebuilding, development, and reconciliation after more than a decade of war?” “Hearing” such questions surely requires us to hear the words of one who tells us, “Do not be afraid.” Yet questions such as these seem to me to be the questions we will ask as we live in the house of love.

Nevertheless, even though the questions addressed in this volume seem to me to lead us into the house of fear, and thus to be the wrong questions, I am obliged to attempt a response. In what follows, I will speak to them primarily from the Christian nonviolence perspective I sketched in the previous section. Though at points I will suggest how other perspectives within the “family” might address an issue, I cannot be comprehensive or systematic.

CONCEPTIONS OF WAR AND PEACE

For many Christian pacifists, war is understood as rooted most deeply in our “natural” (since the fall) sinful human impulses. Although the use of the term “war” is not limited, at least metaphorically, in this tradition to organized violence between large groups, our sinful human impulses spill over into group egoism, and into organized violence between groups—war. “What causes wars, and what causes fightings among you? Is it not your passions that are at war in your members? You desire and do not have; so you kill. And you covet and cannot obtain, so you fight and wage war” (James 4:1–2a, RSV). This description of war—war as the greedy grasping of selfish egos—sounds more realistic to many advocates of Christian nonviolence than do most moral justifications.

This perspective leads many Christian pacifists to a focus on the need for a voluntary, personal decision to accept the lordship of Christ and to allow God’s power to begin transforming one so that it becomes possible to really love one’s neighbor as oneself, so that it becomes possible even to love one’s enemy, and thus, finally, so that it becomes possible to live nonviolently—without fear, in the house of love. This necessarily involves not only a personal experience, but participation in a community that undergirds and sustains such a commitment. The questions that are asked, the stories that are told, the conceptions of reality, including of God and God’s power, that are communicated, have the effect of creating certain dispositions and orientations of persons within the community that foster a ten-

dency to see things in a way that sustains nonviolent commitment and undergirds nonviolent living.

For Christian pacifists, then, peace would be understood broadly and positively (not simply as the absence of war), like the biblical term *shalom*, “a state of well-being, an all-rightness, an okayness.”¹⁶ This state refers to prosperity and security in the physical realm, to just and healthy relationships in the interpersonal or intergroup realm, and to honesty and integrity in the moral realm.¹⁷ The tradition has been committed to finding ways to live in *shalom* concretely, here and now, within the community of faith and, as much as possible, in relation to the wider world. Though this has never been achieved fully even within the community, many ways of seeking to do so have evolved, including various kinds of mutual aid and sharing (barn-raising is perhaps the most conspicuous example, though persons in a part of the tradition, Hutterites, have held all property in common, and many other kinds of mutual assistance have developed), and immigration when military service was demanded or when lack of land threatened to impoverish permanently some members of the community. Traditionally, elders within the many pacifist churches would visit members before communion to make certain that all serious hurts and conflicts were dealt with so that the body could be united in its celebration of the Lord’s Supper. These practices, and many others, have been designed to foster *shalom* in a full sense, especially within the faith community.¹⁸ Though Quakers have long engaged in “positive peacemaking” in the wider world, in the twentieth century this *shalom*-building in the world (not withdrawal or passivity) has increasingly typified the orientation of other Christian pacifist groups as well.¹⁹

Yet although the vision of peace is broad, encompassing, positive, the tradition has also held that one can be “at peace” with one’s enemies, in situations that are far from *shalom*. One will not always be treated rightly, justly, no matter how much one seeks to treat others that way. In such cases, this tradition has encouraged injured persons (and others knowing of the injury) to seek redress by confronting the party doing wrong (following the model of Matt. 18:15–17, for example, in cases involving other believers). Pacifism is not passive acceptance of abuse. Yet the tradition has also stressed the need to forgive repeated offenses (Matt. 18:21–22), to let go of hurt, anger, animosity, to forego retaliation.

You have heard it said, an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth, but I say unto you, do not resist one who is evil. But if any one strikes you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also. . . . You have heard that it was said, “You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.” But I say to you, Love your enemy and pray for those who persecute you. . . . For if you love those who

love you, what reward have you? Do not even the tax collectors do the same? (Matt. 5:38–46)

With the enablement of God's transforming love, one need not either hate or return evil to one who does harm. Again, the tradition is full of stories that illustrate this, and that undergird commitment to live this way, the foremost being Jesus on the cross: "Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing" (Luke 23:34). Another central story from the Anabaptist Mennonite tradition is that of Dirk Willems. Dirk's story is retold in *The Martyrs Mirror*, a book second in importance only to the Bible in Mennonite homes for generations. It is a bloody, 1,100-page account of Christians being martyred for their faith, often at the hands of other Christians. Dirk, the court record shows, was apprehended and confessed to his crimes: that

he was rebaptized in Rotterdam . . . and that he, further, in Asperen, at his house, at divers hours, harbored and admitted secret conventicles and prohibited doctrines, and that he also has permitted several persons to be rebaptized in his aforesaid house; all of which is contrary to our holy Christian faith, and to the decrees of his royal majesty, and ought not to be tolerated, but severely punished, for an example to others.

Therefore, the judges condemned Dirk to be "executed with fire, until death ensues." Dirk escaped from prison and ran across some thin ice to get away from the "thief-catcher" who was sent after him.

The thief-catcher following him broke through, when Dirk Willems, perceiving that the former was in danger of his life, quickly returned and aided him in getting out, and thus saved his life. The thief-catcher wanted to let him go, but the burgomaster, very sternly called to him to consider his oath, and thus he was again seized by the thief-catcher, and . . . put to death at the lingering fire."²⁰

Shalom living in the midst of a sinful world demands the ability to forgive and love even when an enemy continues to treat us as an enemy, to continue to repay evil with good even in the face of injustice. "Heroes" exemplifying this, like Dirk, shape character in rather different ways than heroes like Rambo.

ATTITUDES TOWARD WAR AND NONVIOLENCE

As is clear from what has been said previously, there is a very strong presumption against war within the tradition of Christian nonviolence. For most within this tradition, we might say that the presumption is absolute, allowing no exceptions. It may be worth reiterating, however, that although Christian pacifism has generally been rooted in a theological/ethical framework that interprets Christian ethics as requiring renunciation of

violence in order to conform to the mind of Christ, other grounds for a presumption against violence are present in other strands of the tradition of Christian nonviolence.

These grounds include the claim that other structures can and should be put into place that would provide alternative means for resolving conflicts in more orderly and less destructive ways than war offers (abolitionism), and the claim that there are other more effective means for overthrowing unjust regimes or for defending against aggression that are less costly and thus are to be preferred on pragmatic grounds to war (nonviolent resistance). There is nothing logically inconsistent about holding all three arguments for the presumption against war, and many standing within this tradition do so. It might also be worth noting that although the arguments in favor of abolitionism and nonviolent resistance are often made on the grounds of pragmatic considerations (perhaps at least in part in order to appeal to others who seem to base decisions on pragmatic considerations), those who have advanced such arguments or have found them most compelling are frequently committed to nonviolence as an ethical principle. Whether this is a matter of wishful thinking, wanting to “have one’s cake and eat it too,” or whether it is a case where commitment to an ethical principle enables one to “see” viable alternatives that are not visible from perspectives that typically dominate ethical thought in the West cannot be resolved here.

One further note. Persons standing within the tradition of Christian nonviolence generally respond to wars with a deep feeling of sadness. War represents for Christian pacifists an ultimate symbol of human fallenness. This sense of war’s sinfulness sometimes leads to angry denunciations of it or to a sinful smugness (“we” are not sinful like “they” are), but more deeply and authentically it leads to soul-searching for both the roots of war and conflict within oneself and one’s community, for ways to act concretely to relieve the suffering that wars bring, and increasingly, in modern times, for ways to facilitate the avoidance of and/or ending of wars. I have in mind here, of course, the various abolitionist projects one associates with the figures described in the section on abolitionism, but also particularly Quaker (though not exclusively Quaker) efforts to foster dialogues between conflicting groups in contexts where options for settling differences can be explored informally and off the record.²¹

THE GROUNDS FOR WAR

Though the tradition of Christian nonviolence recognizes many *reasons* for war, often running along the lines noted above under “Conceptions of War and Peace,” all those within the tradition would claim that there are virtually never “legitimate grounds” for war, and most would hold that

there are never such grounds. As noted earlier, some abolitionists are not opposed to personal participation in all wars. Historically, the willingness of abolitionists to sanction war has come mainly when a war is seen as necessary in order to end war. The First World War as the war to end war is the prime example.²² In a somewhat related way, abolitionists have sometimes been willing to approve of wars that are deemed necessary in order to create a situation of “justice” that is seen as a prerequisite for peace in a positive (shalom-like) sense. Thus some whom I have called “abolitionist” (in relation to abolishing war) sanctioned the American civil war as a necessity to abolish the injustice of slavery.²³ Also, in recent times, some abolitionists have sanctioned, or at least have been unwilling to criticize, wars of “national liberation” or wars against “oppressive” regimes.²⁴ In addition, there have been apocalyptic groups who were committed to pacifism in the present age, but who were also ready to pick up the sword to help usher in the kingdom of God upon Christ’s return. Some of these groups have decided that the time to fight has arrived, and have therefore abandoned their pacifism in favor of a righteous war.²⁵

It is also the case that a certain “particularism” in a “typical” Christian pacifist perspective (this particularism has been less true of Quakers than of most other pacifist groups) that expects those committed to the way of Christ to live in ways that are different from what can be expected in the world has left open the possibility of persons from this perspective providing a certain “quasi-legitimate ground” for wars, not by “Christians,” but by the state. It has been clear from within the tradition of Christian pacifism that *Christians* are called to live by the standards outlined, for example, in Romans 12:

Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse them. . . . Do not repay anyone evil for evil. . . . No, “if your enemies are hungry, feed them; if they are thirsty, give them something to drink; for by doing this you will heap burning coals on their heads.” Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.

But the central text for the state for many Christian pacifists has been Romans 13:1–7, in which Christians are told to “be subject to the governing authorities,” to “do what is good” because “rulers are not a terror to good conduct, but to bad.” Although it has not been worked out systematically, since the focus has been on ethics for the Christian community, sometimes there has been a reluctance to condemn for the state certain wars of the state. This reluctance has its roots in an understanding of the state as given by God to maintain order, to protect the good, and to punish the wicked.

A classical formulation of this view for the Mennonite tradition is stated in the Schleithem Confession dating from the beginning of the movement in 1527: “The sword is an ordering of God outside the perfection of

Christ. It punishes and kills the wicked, and guards and protects the good.”²⁶ This view recognizes the state’s ordering function, its calling to protect the good and restrain the evil; sometimes it even tacitly admits that the state’s ordering function may entail the use of violence, perhaps even war. This recognition perhaps accounts for the fact that although pacifists have opposed participation in wars, some of them have not condemned a government’s waging of certain of those wars (for example, American participation in the Second World War). This position seems to rest, at least in part, on a differentiation between the “vocation” or “calling” of Christ’s disciples and that of the state. This differentiation has not necessarily been seen as meaning that Christians must reject all “governing,” but it has meant that “governing,” as well as everything else, must be done in ways compatible with Christ’s teaching and example—and it has often meant much skepticism about the possibility of governing nations in a Christian manner.²⁷

Having said all this, however, it must also be said that there has been no developed theory that seeks to argue exactly when wars might be “justified” for the state. In fact, “justified” must be in quotation marks, because war and violence are never finally, ultimately, “justified,” from a Christian pacifist perspective. God’s ultimate, final will for everyone is nonviolence. At best, war and violence are penultimately “justified” for persons who do not follow Jesus (as pacifists understand the meaning of that) and who are mandated to carry the ordering function of the state in a fallen world where “ordering” may require war or violence. If pressed on when wars might be “justified” for the state, pacifists within this tradition would perhaps utilize something like just war criteria. More generally, they might be inclined to argue that the appropriate standard for the state in international conflict, as well as in domestic law enforcement, could be derived from the concerns outlined in Romans 13, focusing especially on the state’s responsibility to “protect the good.” Such pacifists would also want to insist that this be done with the least possible degree of violence or coercion.²⁸ It is worth noting that the particularistic perspective reflected in this discussion, although it has deep roots in the Christian pacifist tradition, has increasingly been questioned by those who emphasize that the “lordship of Christ” extends not only over the church (where it is recognized) but over the world (even though it is not recognized there), and that there can therefore be no difference in ethical norm for the state as compared to the church. Persons holding this perspective would be more ready to condemn forthrightly all wars by the state, as well as all Christian participation in wars, while at the same time often being more ready to accept for Christians some “coercion” and “police” functioning than many more “particularistic” pacifists would be. Duane Friesen’s work would be an example of this.²⁹

RESISTANCE TO POLITICAL AUTHORITY

Christian pacifists have been quite ready to resist political authorities on points where they feel obeying political authorities would mean compromising obedience to God. The central text has been, "We must obey God rather than any human authority" (Acts 5:29). This resistance has taken various forms among those within the pacifist tradition, including, obviously, refusal of military service, but also sometimes including refusing to pay taxes used for military purposes, refusal to swear oaths, and refusal to engage in other practices that appear idolatrous. Sometimes pacifists have also seen nationalism, and the human sacrifices made in wars to the "gods" of the nations, as a kind of idolatry to be resisted.³⁰ In recent decades, resistance has also taken the form of pacifist agencies working against government restrictions that prevent them from carrying out their humanitarian programs. A case would be shipping medical supplies to North Vietnam in the early 1970s, thereby violating or circumventing the US policy outlawing "trading with the enemy." Resistance to authority within the Christian pacifist tradition has normally taken the form of "civil disobedience" rather than revolutionary attempts (either violent or nonviolent) to overthrow regimes. Christian pacifists have generally seen Jesus's approach either as nonpolitical or as following a different model of "politics" than that adopted by the revolutionaries of his time, the Zealots.³¹ Often citing a text like Romans 13, they typically have had a rather high regard for the legitimate authority of government (even when it must be disobeyed because of a higher loyalty to God), and also typically have had a low view of what one might hope for from governments. Thus, generally, they have not been inclined to revolutionary activity. The Quakers, however, often have been more hopeful of changing governments than most other pacifist groups have been, and they have thus been more politically active, though still not revolutionary.³²

The "nonviolent resistance" perspective has often been supportive of efforts toward "nonviolent revolution" in oppressive situations and has sought to provide mechanisms for overthrowing oppressive regimes that do not represent the will of the people. A kind of "democratic" standard seems to operate from within this perspective: governments are legitimate when they have the support of the population, and are legitimately overthrown (nonviolently) when they lack such support.

In earlier centuries, Christian pacifists faced with military service generally just sought some way to avoid that service, since it violated their convictions. As more democratic notions about government and citizenship (that is, the notion of being citizens rather than simply subjects) have become more widely prevalent among pacifist groups, pacifists have become active in advocating the "rights" of conscientious objectors, including the

rights of objectors to particular wars. Some pacifists have seen conscientious objection as a means to resist the government and its warmaking machinery, and have therefore sought to upset that machinery by refusing to cooperate with a conscription system. Other pacifists have accepted conscription as a “legitimate” part of a state system of which they do not necessarily approve and in which they do not exercise power, but to which they are subject. Such pacifists have typically not resisted conscription when alternatives to military service are provided, but rather have been grateful that the government has shown respect for their religious convictions. Despite the variations, it is probably fair to say that most Christian pacifist groups have had an underlying attitude of some suspicion or mistrust of governments.

MOTIVE OR INTENTION

The Christian pacifist tradition does focus on motivation or intention when it stresses love of neighbor and love of enemy. Love is certainly a motive and an intention, a desire to seek the best for the other out of compassion. At the same time, pacifists are typically deeply skeptical of views that emphasize that actions should be judged on the basis of motives or intentions when the actions themselves seem to belie the stated motive or intention, or that do not attend to the destructiveness of the actions themselves. Augustine, for example, sometimes focuses on the effects of war on the person waging it in a way that seems to downplay excessively what it means in itself or to its victims:

What is the evil in war? Is it the death of someone who will soon die in any case, that others may live in peaceful subjection? This is mere cowardly dislike, not any religious feeling. The real evils of war are love of violence, revengeful cruelty, fierce and implacable enmity, wild resistance, and the lust of power, and such like.³³

Specifically, pacifists have found it difficult to take very seriously views that, in the case of war, stress that one can really “love” a person and at the same time kill him or her. The point is not that no one could ever kill and still feel compassion for the one being killed, but that this is a mistaken understanding of what Christian love is. Love is not mainly a sentiment or a feeling (though proper motivation is surely a part of it), but an action that concretely seeks the best for the one being loved. In this sense, pacifists have wanted to focus on the inherent quality of actions, as well as intentions or motives. Just as the Book of James argues that “faith by itself, if it has no works, is dead” (James 2:17), pacifists tend to hold that motivations or intentions that do not take the form of *action* understandable by those *receiving* the action as reflective of the motive or intention are dead.

It is as important to focus on the meaning of the action for its recipient as on the meaning of the action for its giver, for our actions are a central part of one of our most fundamental tasks, that of witnessing to, *communicating*, God's love.

All of this does not mean that pacifists have absolutely no interest in differentiating various motives or intentions related to warfare. But pacifists are deeply aware of the human heart's ability to deceive itself and, as a rule, tend to trust actions that are "inherently right" more than motives or intentions that are said to be "good"—even though the actions resulting from these motives or intentions violate normally accepted standards. It also means that pacifists often put more weight on not harming, and less weight on righting the evils of the world through the use of armed force, than many nonpacifists. This issue of self-deception, and of justifying actions that may be harmful to others on the basis of good intentions or good motives, is a central part of pacifists' problems with just war. From a pacifist standpoint, it seems that just war serves almost always to justify or legitimize *our* nation's war (rather than to call it seriously into a "court" where it must bear the burden of proof in showing that the normal presumption against war should be overridden), and to condemn *their* nation's war. And, of course, for "them," it works the same way in reverse.

The story of Dirk Willems calls to mind an additional reason for a typical pacifist skepticism about appeals to motives or intentions that then justify killing others out of love for them. Many of the torturers and killers of Anabaptist and other Christian martyrs claimed (I suspect sincerely) to be acting in love for them—and for other innocent souls who might be misled by them—as they cut off their fingers or put them on the pyre to burn them alive. In the discussions in Jerusalem that are part of the background of this book I was struck by the fact that representatives of some groups that have been relatively powerless (Jews and pacifists) argued for a focus on actions, and that some of those who have been powerful (Catholic advocates of natural law) argued for a focus on intentions and motives. Is such a focus on intentions and motives a luxury of the powerful—or even a way of rationalizing to themselves their hurtful behavior—that the weak cannot afford?³⁴

THE CONDUCT OF WAR

I noted earlier that some abolitionists give up their opposition to war when war seems especially necessary to achieve some crucial end. This can also result in an uncritical attitude regarding the conduct of war. The same has sometimes been true of apocalyptic groups.

Christian pacifists generally have been skeptical of the possibility of moral restraint in warfare once it has begun. In this sense many pacifists

have been “realists.” The violence of warfare has seemed to have its own, escalating, often senseless, logic. It is partly for this reason that pacifists have insisted that the line should be drawn between “war and no war” instead of between “just and unjust war.”

This does not mean that pacifists are committed to the view that war *ought* not be limited by moral constraints. Pacifists would typically side with just war theorists in hoping that wars can be so restrained, though they would be skeptical of the realism of that happening. Some pacifists have in fact tried to take just war seriously and engage it on its own terms in an attempt to strengthen the moral constraints on war. These attempts to take just war seriously have often been disappointing because of being disqualified before the discussion starts (as Paul Ramsey does³⁵), or because it seems very difficult to get many within the just war tradition to define the tradition in such a way that it is even theoretically possible for it to yield a *clear* negative judgment about a specific war, or because so many seem unable to apply a theoretically possible negative judgment to one’s own country’s wars.³⁶

MORALITY IN EXTREMITY

From a Christian pacifist perspective, it is vitally important to begin doing ethics from the “center.” It is always a temptation in ethics to become fixated on “the hard cases,” and in doing so to lose sight of the central affirmations that make the cases hard. From a pacifist perspective, this frequently happens in discussion about war, and just war theory is part of the problem. Just war theory can be viewed (when it is not dismissed as a rationalization for wars, as some pacifists tend to do) as an elaborate system for controlling exceptional resort to war and as thus recognizing the norm of nonviolence that regulates everyday human life. So far so good. Yet the structure of the theory focuses our attention wrongly, on the periphery instead of on the center, on the hard case instead of on the normal case. From the pacifist perspective, the central question relative to international conflict would be something like, “How can we live together without killing each other?” not, as it is in just war thought, “When can war be legitimately waged, and how?” From a pacifist perspective, in other words, this elaborate theory too often has the effect of making war look “normal,” rather than like an exception, and therefore has the effect of almost automatically justifying a nation’s wars, and distracting us from what is most important—finding ways to hold to our key convictions rather than figuring out when we have to make exceptions to them. From a pacifist perspective, just war theory is a case of the tail wagging the dog. If the accuracy of this assessment is doubted, consider the following questions. Why is it that we have an enormously elaborated and nuanced moral theory about “just

war,” but no similarly elaborated and nuanced moral theory of “just diplomacy” or “just international relations” or “just peace”? Why is it that in this book, called “The Ethics of War and Peace,” the great bulk of our time is spent focusing on *war*—if, when, and how to engage in it—rather than on *peace*—how to build and maintain it? Even more concretely (if more removed from just war theory and this book), why do we spend, in the United States, more than \$250 billion annually on our military, and a tiny fraction of that on diplomacy, economic aid, support for the United Nations, etc.? The point is that if we attended to the central question (from a pacifist perspective) and put both our theoretical and our financial resources into addressing it, we might well have far fewer situations where we need to address the “exception” that just war is designed to address.

Thus pacifists are skeptical of approaching ethics through the extreme cases rather than through the ordinary cases, where, often enough, we do not act ethically anyway. From this viewpoint, the most basic problem of ethical living is failing to do what we know we should do because it may be costly to do so, not deciding when to make exceptions to the normal rules that govern our lives.

All of this is not to deny that pacifists face awkward questions when asked things like, “How can you just stand by and let Muslim women be raped and murdered in Bosnia?” There are things for pacifists to say to response to such questions. These include noting that pacifist prescriptions for policy have normally been ignored in the years leading up to the crisis and then, suddenly, we are asked for a solution to a problem caused by someone else’s policies. They include observing that often pacifists are not just “standing by” but are deeply involved in working to solve such problems in ways compatible with their convictions, often at considerable cost or risk to themselves. They include pointing to other options that may not have been attempted. And they include simply confessing that we have often not done what we could have done. Other responses could be added. But I grant that they are hard questions. And I grant that perhaps, in theory, just war theory may have more satisfying answers (from many perspectives) to them. But even if one is convinced that something like just war theory can yield a theoretically more satisfactory answer to a hard question about a hard case like Bosnia, are we really farther ahead morally by building an elaborate moral system to deal with the hard case? Might we not be farther ahead if we learned to say simply, “Killing is wrong,” and refused to systematize war morally (and therefore legitimize it morally)? After all, it must be the case, simply on statistical grounds, that less than half of the world’s wars can be objectively just according to just war criteria themselves. From the just war perspective, no war can be just objectively on both sides, and many wars (colonial wars where countries fight each other to take over someone else’s territory, wars waged out of desire to satisfy the

vanity of rulers, etc.) are just on neither side. In this light, and in light of the consistent tendency of persons in opposing countries to justify their own country's wars, pacifism seems a safer moral wager than trying to guess the rightness of wars.

This does not mean that pacifists can avoid the question of extremity. But, as should by now be evident, for pacifists, indeed for all within the tradition of Christian nonviolence, the issue of "extremity" arises at a different point (in one sense) than it does for those within the tradition of just war thinking. From the pacifist perspective, the question of extremity is not whether the normal rules of warfare can in certain extreme cases be overridden, but whether the presumption against any and all war can ever be overridden in an extreme case. Despite this difference, however, it is worth noting that it is not only the pacifist who is faced with the uncomfortable choice of holding to his or her moral principles or abandoning them in the face of what seems to be an overriding necessity. Like pacifists, just war theorists, if they hold to a "strict constructionist" view of just war theory, sometimes will need to choose between their moral principles and seeming "effectiveness" in reaching their (ostensibly just) goals. Indeed, any moral view that does not yield finally to a purely consequentialist perspective faces the same apparent collision between morality and necessity.

It is crucial to note, however, that from a Christian pacifist perspective, there is no such thing as "absolute necessity." There is only "necessity" in relationship to achieving certain ends that are deemed more important than holding to one's ethical commitments. Near the very root of Christian pacifist commitment is the freedom from the "necessity" to value my life, or the lives of my friends, above the lives of others, since my life, and the lives of my friends, are "safe" in God's hands. In like manner, Christian pacifists are also freed from the burden of "making history come out right."³⁷ Such pacifists insist that history is finally in God's control, and that it is our responsibility to act as Jesus teaches us to act, and that as we do so, God will bring about the outcome of history that God intends. We are simply not smart enough to know what the outcomes of our various actions will be. (In a certain way, a realistic appraisal of our limitations in forecasting outcomes itself is a strong argument for pacifism). We have no "responsibility" to violate standards revealed to us in order to help God out. This does not mean, of course, that we do not calculate consequences or that we ought not use our human intelligence to achieve good instead of evil. Yet the conviction that we do not bear the burden of history's outcome alone frees us from a compulsiveness about stopping what we perceive as evil or achieving what we perceive as good that, in the final analysis from a Christian pacifist perspective, reflects a kind of functional atheism. There are, after all, many evils that we simply, physically, *cannot* prevent, many goods we *cannot* bring about—because we are not God. Why should

we feel compelled to try (with varying and unknown probabilities of success) to prevent those evils or bring about those goods if the only way we can do so involves violating our moral commitments? From this perspective, our responsibility for “making history come out right” is limited not only by our power to influence history’s outcome (which pacifists often feel is much more modest than that of those who are used to ruling the world), but also by our higher responsibility to live in ways consonant with God’s revelation to us in Jesus Christ.

There is one more approach to the issue of “extremity.” In contrast to most politicians and many moralists, Michael Walzer argues for a stringent criterion to govern “extremity,” what he calls (following Churchill) “supreme emergency.” He says, in effect, that we should not be like Chicken Little, always contending that the sky is falling, thus rationalizing immoral action on the basis of “necessity.” Unlike Chicken Little, we should only violate the rules of war when “the heavens are (really) about to fall.”³⁸

One way for a Christian pacifist to respond to Walzer’s view is to ask, “Will the heavens fall? Can the heavens fall?” Another way is to ask, “Have the heavens fallen?” when nations have lost wars. In responding to these questions, much, obviously, depends on what one means by the “heavens.” Walzer’s way of putting the issue makes it evident that, for him, the “heavens” means something like, “my nation, or some political community with important moral commitments, good political institutions, etc.” If this falls, the heavens fall. A view like this seems implicit in all views that defend the rightness of violating normal norms in war in the face of extremity, if only because wars are fought to defend political communities, nations.

A Christian pacifist response to these questions might go like this. On the one hand, the heavens surely *will* fall, no matter what we do to hold them up—we are not God—if we identify the heavens with our political community or ideology. No political community will last forever, whatever we do to preserve it. There is simply no way to hold the heavens up in the long run. If that time frame seems too grand, note also that it is the very thing that makes a political community most worth defending that is destroyed first when that community violates its own standards of right under the pressure of “necessity.” Are the “heavens” the physical continuity of a certain nation or of its moral commitments?

On the other hand, I would insist that the heavens *cannot* fall. The heavens did not fall when Athens fell, when Rome fell, when . . . fell. They will not fall when the United States falls. They will not even fall when, in one way or another, the earth is destroyed. These are claims, I take it, that Christians make when we speak of God’s providence, power, goodness, eternity, and of our ultimate destiny as being somehow with God. And they are claims that deny that any nation or political ideology or system amounts to “the heavens.”

These observations about extremity get us back to the central claims of the pacifist position that I represent, a position that is finally dependent upon a conviction about God and God's action in the world (and its implications for our action) that is known to us in Jesus Christ. In the absence of faith in the God of Jesus Christ, this sort of pacifism is certainly foolishness. But, "to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ [is] the power of God and the wisdom of God. For God's foolishness is wiser than human wisdom, and God's weakness is stronger than human strength" (1 Cor. 1:24–25).

EPILOGUE

Earlier in this chapter, I told the story of Dirk Willems. His death was part of a "debate" over religious truth. In sixteenth-century Europe it was believed, functionally at least, that questions of truth could be settled by torture and killing. I am personally grateful that in the conference at Jerusalem we sought to find the truth in a different way! This other way of seeking truth is not uncommon in our world today. In a way, this rightly can be interpreted as a triumph of toleration. But we might also interpret this in a slightly different way. Someone has said, "We are all Marxists now," in the sense of recognizing that material interests are important shapers of action. I believe it is fair to say that in a similar way, in relation to questions of religious and philosophical truth claims, "We are all pacifists now." This is to say that Christian pacifists are committed to the propositions that our only "weapons" are words (and the way we live), that the most powerful power is finally the power of truth, and that one can only convince someone of something by . . . well, by *convincing* them, not by forcing them. Most intellectuals are now committed to this same proposition when it comes to understanding the truth. This "triumph" of pacifism is a cause for rejoicing—at least for those of us who are pacifists!

It is ironic—no, sad—however, that we in late twentieth-century Western culture do not believe that the "right" thing in relationships between peoples and nations must also be determined by using nothing other than words as "weapons," by relying on nothing other than the power of truth, the power of moral appeal. In settling questions of right between nations, we are still in the equivalent of the sixteenth century—we still use the methods used in that century to settle questions of religious truth. Is this because we simply have not "seen" in relation to political conflicts what we have "seen" in relation to the quest for philosophical or religious truth? Or is it because what matters to us now is not "true" religion, but our own and our nation's ideologies and interests? I frankly think it is probably mainly the latter. If this is true, there is less reason for rejoicing from a Christian pacifist perspective. If this is true, it means that we no longer take God

seriously enough to fight over religion, but now as much or more than ever, we bow before idols of our own making—nations, and political ideologies and interests—and we make sacrifices on their altars, human sacrifices by the millions in the form of wars' victims. One of the hard theoretical questions put to me during the conference was whether I would not act violently to prevent the takeover of a civilized country by "barbarians," barbarians who even went so far as to practice human sacrifice. A good question. But I fear that the barbarians are not out there. We are the barbarians, complete with human sacrifice.

As long as we believe that the power that "wins" by dominating others, by cowing others into submission—the kind of power symbolized best by military force—is the strongest power, we will remain barbarians. As long as we believe that, we will be doomed to wars and more wars. But when we come to see that the power of truth, spoken and lived, is finally more powerful—when we come to see and accept the power of the cross through which Jesus disarmed the principalities and powers—then we will be free. The truth will set us free. Free from the need to compel others to conform to our visions of the right. Free from the fear that makes us submit to injustice. Free from the fear of death. And free from war.

NOTES

1. See John H. Yoder, *Nevertheless: Varieties of Religious Pacifism*, rev. ed. (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1992), and Peter Brock, *Pacifism in Europe to 1914* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1972), 472–76.

2. Brock has suggested essentially the same three viewpoints, in embryonic form, in the preface to *Freedom from War: Nonsectarian Pacifism, 1814–1914* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1991), vii–viii.

3. John H. Yoder, *Christian Attitudes to War, Peace, and Revolution* (Elkhart, IN: Associated Mennonite Biblical Seminaries, 1983), 372–401.

4. Martin Ceadel, *Thinking about Peace and War* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987), and James Turner Johnson, *The Quest for Peace: Three Moral Traditions in Western Cultural History* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1987).

5. This is by no means an inclusive list. Similar pacifist movements have appeared in many other times and places, though the pacifism of such movements has often been short-lived. This happened, for example, in nineteenth-century America. See Yoder, *Christian Attitudes*, 299–317, for a brief description. Also see the forthcoming book tentatively titled *Proclaim Peace: Voices of Christian Pacifism in America Outside the Historic Peace Churches*, edited by Richard Hughes and Theron F. Schlabach. For additional examples, see both 1991 volumes by Brock: *Freedom from Violence: Sectarian Nonresistance from the Middle Ages to the Great War* and *Freedom from War: Nonsectarian Pacifism, 1814–1914* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press).

6. Roland H. Bainton, *Christian Attitudes toward War and Peace* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1960), 178–84.

7. Brock, *Freedom from War*.
8. Cf. Yoder, *Christian Attitudes*, 319–40.
9. For additional expressions of Christian nonviolent resistance perspectives, see Philip McManus and Gerald Schlabach, eds., *Relentless Persistence: Nonviolent Action in Latin America* (Philadelphia, PA: New Society Publishers, 1991), and Dominique Barbé, *Grace and Power: Base Communities and Nonviolence in Brazil* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1987).
10. As I understand it, this is one central point of Stanley Hauerwas's essay, "Can a Pacifist Think about War?" (in Hauerwas, *Dispatches from the Front* [Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1994]), a point I wish to illustrate here and to make concrete.
11. There is literature exploring the connection between worship and ethics of which I became aware after drafting this chapter. See, for example, Vigen Guroian, "Seeing Worship as Ethics: An Orthodox Perspective," *Journal of Religious Ethics* 13 (1985), 332–39.
12. Walter Sawatsky, "Truth Telling in Eastern Europe: The Liberation and the Burden," *Journal of Church and State* 33 (1991), 701–29, and Timothy Garton Ash, *The Magic Lantern: The Revolution of '89 Witnessed in Warsaw, Budapest, Berlin and Prague* (New York: Random House, 1990).
13. Henri J. M. Nouwen, *Lifesigns: Intimacy, Fecundity, and Ecstasy in Christian Perspective* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1986), 18.
14. Nouwen, *Lifesigns*, 17–20.
15. Nouwen, *Lifesigns*, 20–21.
16. Perry B. Yoder, *Shalom: The Bible's Word for Salvation, Justice, and Peace* (Newton, KS: Faith and Life Press, 1987), 12.
17. The term "positive peace," used frequently in the modern peace studies movement, has a similar meaning. See, for example, the introductory text by David P. Barash, *Introduction to Peace Studies* (Belmont, CA: Wadsworth Publishing Company, 1991), 9–11.
18. Although it speaks to a somewhat different time and setting, for a fleshing out of what this has meant concretely from within this tradition, see Guy F. Hershberger, *The Way of the Cross in Human Relationships* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1958).
19. For an overview of what one Christian pacifist organization is doing to make the peace commitment an active and positive movement, rather than simply a passive refusal to participate in war, see the annual "Workbook" of the Mennonite Central Committee, Akron, PA 17501.
20. Thieleman J. van Braght, *The Bloody Theater or Martyrs Mirror of the Defenseless Christians* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1968 [original in Dutch, 1660]), 741–42.
21. See the book on Quaker conciliation efforts by C. H. Mike Yarrow, *Quaker Experiences in International Conciliation* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1978). There is also growing involvement of Mennonites in conciliation efforts, both locally and internationally. See the newsletter *Conciliation Quarterly*, published by the Mennonite Central Committee, Akron, PA 17501, for regular reporting of Mennonite and related activity in this area.
22. Cf. Ray H. Abrams, *Preachers Present Arms* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1969 [original 1933]), esp. 161ff.

23. Cf. Peter Brock, *Freedom from War*, 117ff.
24. At least, this is a key criticism of some who are called "pacifists." Cf. Guenter Lewy, *Peace and Revolution: The Moral Crisis of American Pacifism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), but also various objections to Lewy's interpretation in Michael Cromartie, ed., *Peace Betrayed? Essays on Pacifism and Politics* (Washington, DC: Ethics and Public Policy Center, 1990).
25. Cf. James M. Stayer, *Anabaptists and the Sword*, 2d ed. (Lawrence, KS: Coronado Press, 1976), chs. 4 and 11–12.
26. *The Schleithelm Confession*, trans. and ed. John Howard Yoder (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1973), 14. "Sword" here refers to the coercive, order-maintaining function of the government. It does not refer specifically to warmaking (28 n. 44).
27. For a sampling of sixteenth-century Anabaptist views, see Walter Klaassen, ed., *Anabaptism in Outline: Selected Primary Sources* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1981), 244–64.
28. Cf. Ted Koontz, "Mennonites and the State: Preliminary Reflections," *Essays on Peace Theology and Witness: Occasional Papers*, no. 12 (Elkhart, IN: Institute of Mennonite Studies, 1988), 35–60.
29. Duane K. Friesen, *Christian Peacemaking and International Conflict* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1986).
30. Cf. Dale Aukerman, *Darkening Valley: A Biblical Perspective on Nuclear War* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1989). The activities of people like the Berrigans provide an example.
31. Cf. John Howard Yoder, *The Politics of Jesus* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1972), esp. ch. 2.
32. Peter Brock, *The Quaker Peace Testimony: 1660–1914* (York: Sessions Book Trust [distributed in the US by Syracuse University Press], 1990), is the best recent overview of Quaker pacifism.
33. Quoted in Arthur F. Holmes, ed., *War and Christian Ethics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1975), 64.
34. For a perceptive discussion of some roots of Christian religious "coercion" of other Christians, see Peter Brown, *Religion and Society in the Age of St. Augustine* (New York: Harper and Row, 1972), 260–78, 301–31.
35. Paul Ramsey, *The Just War: Force and Political Responsibility* (New York: Scribner, 1968), 259ff.
36. John Howard Yoder's book, *When War Is Unjust* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1984), is one example of a pacifist attempt to engage just war theory on its own terms. On the Gulf War, see also Yoder, "Just War Tradition: Is It Credible?" *Christian Century* (13 Mar. 1991), 295–98.
37. John Howard Yoder, *Politics of Jesus*, 233–50.
38. Michael Walzer, *Just and Unjust Wars* (New York: Basic Books, 1977), 231.